Akbar’s birth, whether it was Hamida Banu’s mysteriously shining brows, Humayun’s visions, or Jiji Anaga’s lucent dreams. It was in this spirit, argues A. Azfar Moin, that Humayun’s astrological preoccupations and frequent auguries were interpreted as being premonitions of impending greatness. The *Akbarnama* even has a long digression to include in Akbar’s genealogy the rather obscure Alanqua, a princess of Moghulistan, who was impregnated by a divine light to give birth to three ‘shining sons’. The implication was clear—Akbar was above the limitations of ordinary human forefathers with their pedestrian ambitions and expected frailties. Instead, the *Akbarnama* described the life of a monarch who demonstrated miraculous powers from infancy. A monarch who commanded rampaging elephants, succumbed to visions, articulated prophesies, and cured people using his holy breath. A monarch, moreover, who did not rule only Muslim subjects. Instead, Abu’l Fazl wrote about a king who used imagery from many faiths while crafting a faultless persona. Through fire worship, the veneration of the sun, mantras and austerities, fasts, and the translation of the sacred works of the Hindus, Akbar became the insaan-e-kamil* and peshwa of the spiritual age.

Since Abu’l Fazl needed to show that the Padshah was above all limitations of religion, events described in the *Akbarnama* were relentless about showing the Padshah in a positive light. Every occurrence was interpreted in the light of Akbar’s later immaculate grandeur and all earlier foibles were explained as a need by Akbar to ‘veil’ his true self and to test those around him. That Abu’l Fazl was intensely admiring of the Padshah is evident and he found in Akbar a great monarch worthy of his own boundless energies and dedication. It is nonetheless tempting to wonder whether there was not also a splinter of anger in Abu’l Fazl when he poured all his fierce energy into the *Akbarnama* into making the Padshah a Mujtahid of the Age which served to eviscerate and make redundant his sworn enemies, the ulema.

For all his passionate arguments in favour of reason, or aql, above all else and above received wisdom, an incident occurred in the 1590s that showed the truth to be rather more complicated for Abu’l Fazl. The *Maasir ul-Umara** describes an episode in which Salim went to visit Abu’l Fazl in his home and was astounded to discover forty clerks busily copying the Koran, a Muslim act of piety. Salim, who was becoming increasingly leery of Abu’l Fazl’s closeness to Akbar, immediately appropriated clerks and